

( Translation of a Chinese paper stuck up in the streets of Ning po;—copied and forwarded to a friend at Su-chao, and by him to his correspondent in Canton.)

### BRIEF ACCOUNT OF THE ENGLISH CHARACTER.

The English people inhabit a country, at the distance of 16,000 miles from China;—at least this space is passed over by ships, from the necessity of their proceeding round the southern continent of Africa. Some idea may be formed of the spirit and enterprise of a nation, whose vessels traverse so vast an ocean, in safety and with facility.—They frequently encounter severe tempests, but from the skill of their officers, and the bold and daring character of the seamen, ships are rarely lost. Pirates or enemies do not venture to attack them. They bring the manufactures and productions of remote countries, and receive in exchange those of China. By this means the subjects, both of the Chinese and British Empires, are enriched, industry is greatly encouraged, and men are rendered happy and useful members of society.

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### 英吉利國人品國事略說

英國人原居之地距中華有七萬  
往南轉亞非里加州之大地方遂  
這樣遠路既英國人坐船快捷安  
海洋其敢爲本事可見也有時伊  
賴船主夥長等之善策梢人之膽  
之患又且在洋面海賊國敵等都  
英國船所帶進口的係遠國之土



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Title: Brief Account of the English Character

Author: Charles Marjoribanks

Translator: Robert Morrison

Release date: May 31, 2017 [eBook #54820]

Most recently updated: October 23, 2024

Language: English, Chinese

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## **Brief Account of the English Character**

### Compiler's Note

Believing in the power of print in converting and “educating” the Chinese, nineteenth-century European traders and missionaries invested significant amounts of energy and money in the dissemination of tracts on the China coast. One of these ephemera was \_\_\_\_\_, "Brief Account of the English Character." It was first drafted in English by Charles Marjoribanks, president of the English East India Company's Select Committee in Canton. Robert Morrison (\_\_\_\_\_), a missionary-cum-sinologist, translated the manuscript into Chinese and printed hundreds of copies at his \_\_\_\_\_ (Anglo-Chinese College) in Malacca (Melaka). In 1832, despite his colleagues' objection, Marjoribanks engaged Charles Gutzlaff (\_\_\_\_\_ or \_\_\_\_\_), a German missionary, and Hugh Hamilton Lindsay, the Company's supercargo, to make an illegal voyage to China's coastal waters in order to “ascertain how far the northern ports of the Chinese empire may be gradually opened to British commerce” ([Ship Amherst](#), p.3). He asked the voyagers to load a ship with English products for sale as well as cases of his pamphlet for distribution.

What follows is a side-by-side bilingual e-text of the tract. On the left is Marjoribanks's English manuscript, anonymously edited and published in *The Canton Register* dated July 18, 1832 (\_\_\_\_\_). On the right is a complete transcription of the

Chinese tract with punctuation added. Typographical errors in both texts were not corrected. Please scroll down to see page images of each document; the Chinese tract's images are courtesy of Harvard-Yenching Library Chinese Rare Books Digitization Project.

Besides the edited one in *The Canton Register*, there is another extant, unedited manuscript of Marjoribanks's, housed in the British Library. My earlier work, "Representing 'Great England' to Qing China in the Age of Free Trade Imperialism: The Circulation of a Tract by Charles Marjoribanks on the China Coast" provides the full text of this manuscript and an introduction; please visit NINES (*Nineteenth Century Scholarship Online*):

[http://www.nines.org/exhibits/Representing\\_Great\\_England?page=1](http://www.nines.org/exhibits/Representing_Great_England?page=1)

Ting Man Tsao, Ph.D.

## **Brief Account of the English Character**

**[Charles Marjoribanks]**

**The Canton Register**

**5.10 (July 18, 1832): p.68-69**

**[ Robert Morrison ]**

## **BRIEF ACCOUNT OF THE ENGLISH CHARACTER.**

The English people inhabit a country, at the distance of 16,000 miles from China;—at least this space is passed over by ships, from the necessity of their proceeding round the southern continent of Africa. Some idea may be formed of the spirit and enterprise of a nation, whose vessels traverse so vast an ocean, in safety and with facility.—They frequently encounter severe tempests, but from the skill of their officers, and the bold and daring character of the seamen, ships are rarely lost. Pirates or enemies do not venture to attack them. They bring the manufactures and productions of remote countries, and receive in exchange those of China. By this means the subjects, both of the Chinese and British Empires, are enriched, industry is greatly encouraged, and men are rendered happy and useful members of society.



The English have traded for upwards of two hundred years with China, and from sixty to eighty vessels under the English flag, are frequently within twelve months, in the Chinese waters. To how many tens of thousands of natives does not such a commerce give useful employment!

The policy of the English government has often in China been most falsely represented, and it has been stated to be ambitious, and desirous of increase of territory. No assertion can be more distant from truth. The dominions of England are already so large, that the policy of the government is rather to diminish than to enlarge them. Besides the mother country, it has several valuable possessions in Europe; it has large territories in North America; and numerous islands in the West Indies. The Cape of Good Hope, in Africa, belongs to it; it has several prosperous settlements in Australia; numerous islands in Asia are subject to its rule; and the ancient territory of Hindostan with all the regions pertaining thereto, is now included in the British Empire. The small settlements of Penang,

Martaban, Malacca, and Singapore, are those most contiguous to China. The government of so great an Empire has no thirst for conquest. Its great object and aim is to preserve its subjects in a condition of happiness and tranquillity. But while most desirous of doing so, it is very jealous of insult, and ever ready to avenge oppression and injustice.

The object and endeavour of the English in China have always been to carry on a pacific and amicable intercourse, but their anxiety to do so has, on several occasions, been frustrated. The benevolent disposition of the great Emperor of China has induced him to state his desire, to treat remote foreigners with indulgence and consideration: but the Imperial benevolence of mind has, on several occasions, in past years, been opposed, by subordinates officers of his government. Foreigners trading to Canton have been heavily taxed and oppressed; and commerce has been greatly impeded by the exactions to which it has been exposed. Natives have repeatedly been heavily fined and punished, sometimes cruelly tortured



and put to death, for alleged treasonable connection with the English, whose only object was to conduct a commercial intercourse in tranquillity, and to obey the Imperial laws. In addition to the government duties, large sums of money have been forced from native merchants, and bribes have been received by inferior officers. Both natives and foreigners have been subject to these oppressions. The Imperial ear is too remote that even the echo of such things should be heard, for they are often done in darkness and silence; but the great and enlarged mind of the Emperor can never approve of such acts on the part of his servants.

Printed placards have even been affixed to the walls of public buildings, traducing the foreign character, and encouraging low and degraded natives to insult strangers who resort to China. Affrays and riots have frequently in consequence taken place; the public peace has been disturbed, and commercial intercourse interrupted. How much are the police officers to blame, who do not put an end to such improper and unjust proceedings! English

sailors are often rude in manner, though kind in disposition. They cannot bear insult;—hence riots take place, wounds are inflicted, and death is sometimes the consequence. On board English ships that resort to China, strict discipline is preserved, and the men are immediately punished, if they commit violent acts, towards natives or others: but discipline is of little avail, if low natives are encouraged by low officers, to insult and attack them. The laws of England make no distinction of persons, and an Englishman is as severely punished for an act of violence towards a Chinese as he is for one towards a fellow-countryman.

The manners and customs of all nations are different. With just allowance made for such difference, why should not Chinese and Englishmen live together on terms of friendly cordiality? The commands of the Sovereign of England to his subjects are, wherever they go in the world, to endeavour to maintain an amicable and pacific intercourse with the people of the country, but never to be forgetful of their national name

or honor. When Chinese subjects arrive in England, or in any other part of the English dominions, they live under the protection of the laws, which are equally administered to them with the natives of the country. Their wrongs and injuries are all equally redressed.

Instead, then, of being encouraged to acts of enmity towards each other, why should not Chinese and English strive together, which should most excel in acts of beneficence and kindness? In many instances, natives of China, who have been found shipwrecked on barren islands, in the midst of the boisterous ocean, have been saved by the crews of English vessels, —unfortunate men who must otherwise have perished in want and misery. British sailors have long been distinguished for such acts of humanity, and are taught to glory in them, more than even in deeds of war. Yet these are the persons whom the natives of China are sometimes told, by designing men, to insult and despise.

The people of China are highly intelligent, industrious, and prosperous; but they are not the only



people in the World that are so. Ignorant men have sometimes foolishly taught, that all that is good is centred in China, but that the rest of the earth is worthless. — How vain and childish is the man who reasons thus!—If he had visited other countries, he would have discovered, that Heaven had in its bounty and mercy bestowed manifold blessings on many other regions of the earth. In England, the people live in tranquility; their persons and property are protected by the laws; their religion inculcates peace upon earth and good will towards all men; they have arrived at a wonderful state of improvement in arts and science, and in the cultivation of all those means which serve to civilize mankind. They are feared in times of war, and honored in times of peace. There is no country with which it is more the interest of China to remain on terms of friendly intercourse than England. It carries on a great and lucrative commerce with this Empire, and the confines of its Indian dominions almost border upon those of China. One river which rises in Yun-nan flows through a portion of the British territory.

It is much to the honor of Chinese merchants, that they are strict and accurate in their commercial dealings, and in some instances have shewn acts of much liberality to foreigners. The pride of a British merchant is to be just and liberal in his dealings. The high name and reputation of the English East India Company in China has long been established; the promise of its servants is as good as money accurately weighed, and its faith pledged in any mercantile transaction has never once been broken. Let the people of China think profoundly upon these things, and not treat lightly persons of this stamp and character. Let the officers of government, in accordance with the decrees of the benevolent Emperor of China, treat foreigners with the respect and consideration to which they are entitled. Then, indeed, will there be peace, union, and harmony, between the native and British Community in China.

A friend to China and England, whose anxious desire is the happiness of his fellow-men, traces

with a feeble pen this hasty and  
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[Header, p.67]



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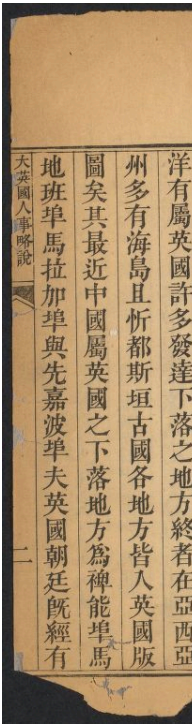
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賴船主夥長等之善策梢人之膽行未幾何致破船  
之患又在洋面海賊國敵等都不敢向攻也  
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英國國朝之志意屢被人在東土妄稱及卽有假言  
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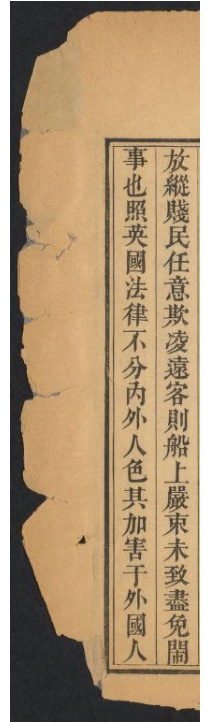
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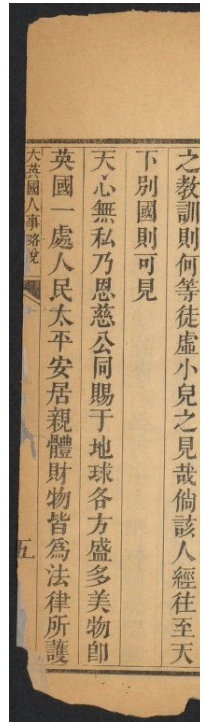
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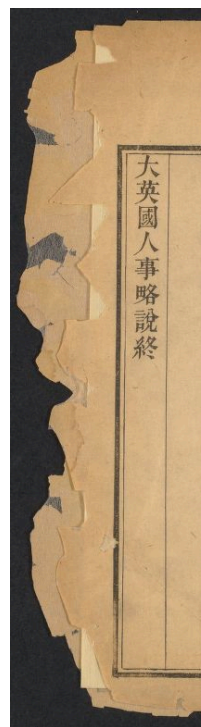
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